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Purity and exile

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The following excerpt of an interview summarizes points brought up by many informants in their chronicles of early hardship.

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Apart from problems of food and lodging, the gravest problems were only that the citizens considered us to be savage animals. I say this because, sometimes, if one hit a Burundian, it was said, "Hit harder, it is a refugee." For this, we found ourselves to be without value in their eyes. [...] The citizens insulted us in the beginning because they said that we had left our fields, our plantations of palms, coffee, cassava, and had come here without bringing anything. For this, they said that we had come to eat their food. We were not liked because of our poverty. [...] For the moment, the situation has changed; we have bought palm plantations, we have built our own homes, we have become accustomed [to living here].

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The following testimony shows clearly that the early years were associated with social problems and hardships, but it is also of interest because, unlike the mythico-historical accounts of early exile in Mishamo, it fails to make

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explicitly categorical or essentializing judgments about the “locals” or “citizens.” No inherent “traits” are excavated. Indeed, while most people mentioned that early exile was characterized by insults and jokes, they also hastened to add that not all “locals” were alike, and that this problem had to do with particular temperaments, particular situations in the labor market, and particular social contexts. The most frequently made retrospective assessment of the problem was, in the words of one person, that “[t]hose who insulted us and did not like us were above all the drunkards. Sometimes they said that if a refugee dies, it is like an animal dying. But all this was said especially when beer had been bought. All this happens in beer clubs and cabarets.” Yet another person put it thus: “I think that [the insults] were a way of condescending to us. But it was not everyone who insulted us. In general, it was very few persons. It was those who were dishonest, persons who were habitual impolites, those who did not even get along with other citizens.”

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Another significant aspect of the passage cited above is its suggestion that it was somehow understandable for the local, well-established population to resent refugees “because of their poverty.” It acknowledges that “danger” and criminalization may attach to extreme poverty.⁴ Poverty was here seen as a source of stigma; the appropriate remedy was not a protestation of injustice, but an overcoming of poverty.

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4. Cf. Donzelot (1979); Fox-Piven and Cloward (1971).

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